



"We need more women to be a part of the police force and for conditions for them to work and feel safe in this profession to be improved. The presence of women police officers makes many women complainants feel safer and confident to report"

— TEJDEEP KAUR MENON
Ex-DGP, Telangana Special Protection Force



"Even with security guards present, it's always more effective for employees to work alongside their colleagues. Also, shift timings should be changed occasionally to ensure there is no fixed pattern to when employees arrive and leave the office"

— RICHARD LOBO
Chief People Officer, Tech Mahindra

Photo illustration by BANDEEP SINGH

and establish forums for dialogue around preventing sexual harassment. "We often see employers conducting annual training when it should be done at regular intervals," says Vishal Kedia, founder of compliance solutions provider Complykaro.

Safety practices also need to extend beyond corporate offices to the shop floors. Data shows that the most complaints filed per 1,000 women in FY24 came from sectors where employees worked on the shop floor or were engaged in fieldwork. Aware of this, agriculture and chemicals business conglomerate DCM Shriram has adopted various initiatives. Their chemical plant in the remote village of Jhagadia, Gujarat, which is being commissioned this year, will be managed by eight women. "Since it is an all-women area, there will be 24-hour surveillance, and a woman security guard has been deployed there," says its CHRO Sandeep Girotra. Similarly, in their sugar factories in Hardoi, Uttar Pradesh, a separate women's hostel was built to enable women to take up jobs there. Similarly, at Jindal Stainless's plant in Odisha's Jajpur, women employees don't work night shifts and also get a bus pick-up and drop facility, says the company's CHRO Sushil Baveja.

The workplace today is no longer confined to an office building. Civil society, the government and all others must work towards a systems approach where city infrastructure and amenities are designed with a gender perspective. For instance, a safety audit of Mumbai's Bandra-Kurla Complex found it to be unsafe by design, as the largely commercial area has few footfalls in the evening, making working women feel unsafe when accessing public transport. "What we are proposing for the Mumbai Development Plan is that there should be mixed-use development, not the separation of residential and commercial areas," says Shah.

The gender lens has to extend to mobility and public amenities too. The Udaiti report, for instance, found that 44 per cent of the HR managers in the 200 companies they studied cited transportation and safety issues as significant barriers to recruiting women. At the same time, the introduction of free transport by several states saw many blue-collar workers using it, where earlier they would have to walk 5-6 km daily to get to work. The safety of working women should not be the responsibility of just the employers but a collective societal endeavour where all stakeholders come together to ensure that women can work without fear and contribute to economic progress. If not, Viksit Bharat will be no country for women. ■

–with Jumana Shah, Suhani Singh & Arkamoy Datta Majumdar